

# Denver → Yellowstone — RV Road Trip

9–15 July 2026 | Mr Mark Williams, party of 4 | Road Bear Class C 29–31' | Booking CXF847765-1

Arrive DEN Thu 9 Jul 11:00 · pickup RV 1:30–2:00 PM · drop-off Wed 15 Jul 9:30–10:00 AM · fly 14:05 · Road Bear, 6586 Brighton Blvd, Commerce City · +1 720-570-1100.

***This version:** cowboy gear on the way up, two nights at Fishing Bridge (Lake area), the Cody Nite Rodeo on Sunday, and a relaxed three-leg drive home reaching the Fort Collins lake KOA early. Driving times every day.*

## Route at a glance

| Date       | Overnight         | Driving (approx.) | Highlights                                       |
|------------|-------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Thu 9 Jul  | Casper, WY        | 4h30 / 265 mi     | Land, pickup, big shop, drive north              |
| Fri 10 Jul | Fishing Bridge RV | ~5h50 / 293 mi    | <b>Cowboy store</b> , hot springs, into the park |
| Sat 11 Jul | Fishing Bridge RV | ~3h10 / 128 mi    | Dawn wildlife, then geysers loop                 |
| Sun 12 Jul | Cody, WY          | ~3h10 / 133 mi    | Canyon & Hayden, then <b>rodeo 8 PM</b>          |
| Mon 13 Jul | Casper, WY        | 3h55 / 214 mi     | Easy drive south (optional soak)                 |
| Tue 14 Jul | Fort Collins, CO  | 3h30 / 230 mi     | Arrive early — enjoy the lake!                   |
| Wed 15 Jul | Fly home          | 1h00 / 50 mi      | Drop 9:30–10:00, fly 14:05                       |

The drive home is three short legs instead of one marathon — you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon on Tuesday. Total RV driving ~26 hours / ~1,315 mi of the 1,400 included.

## Where you're staying

| Night      | RV park                                     | Where & how to book                                                      |
|------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Thu 9 Jul  | <a href="#">Casper KOA Journey</a>          | Bar Nunn, off I-25 — <b>book direct</b> , +1 307-577-1664                |
| Fri 10 Jul | <a href="#">Fishing Bridge RV Park</a>      | <b>Inside Yellowstone</b> — Yellowstone NP Lodges, +1 307-344-7311       |
| Sat 11 Jul | <a href="#">Fishing Bridge RV Park</a>      | <b>Inside Yellowstone</b> (2nd night, same site) — Yellowstone NP Lodges |
| Sun 12 Jul | <a href="#">Cody / Yellowstone East KOA</a> | Cody — <b>free rodeo shuttle</b> ; book direct, +1 307-587-2369          |
| Mon 13 Jul | <a href="#">Casper KOA Journey</a>          | Bar Nunn, off I-25 — <b>book direct</b> , +1 307-577-1664                |
| Tue 14 Jul | <a href="#">Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA</a> | Fort Collins — <b>book direct</b> , +1 970-484-9880                      |

**Four nights outside the park you book yourself** (Casper ×2, Cody, Fort Collins — all full hook-ups). Both Yellowstone nights are at Fishing Bridge (the only full-hookup site in the park), booked through Yellowstone National Park Lodges — reservation required, and it fills months ahead for July.

## Book these now (priority order)

- **Road Bear — confirmed:** pickup **1:30–2:00 PM Thu 9 Jul**, drop-off **9:30–10:00 AM Wed 15 Jul** (6586 Brighton Blvd; +1 720-570-1100). Online registration & payment done.
- **Fishing Bridge RV Park × 2 nights** (Fri 10 & Sat 11 Jul, **same site**) — the only full-hookup site in the park, hard-sided rigs only (bear country). Yellowstone NP Lodges: +1 307-344-7311 / 866-439-7375. Combined length ~31 ft. Reservation required — fills months ahead. **Book now.**
- **Cody / Yellowstone East KOA × 1 night** (Sun 12 Jul) — free nightly shuttle to the Cody Nite Rodeo (departs 7 PM), two pools, a hot tub and free pancakes. Reserve at [koa.com/campgrounds/cody](http://koa.com/campgrounds/cody) or +1 307-587-2369 (online booking is

sometimes off — call to confirm).

- **Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12 Jul, 8:00 PM, Stampede Park)** — [codystampederoдео.com](http://codystampederoдео.com) (~\$25–79/seat) or at the gate; gates 7:00 PM. Or ride the KOA's free shuttle (departs 7 PM).
- **Casper KOA Journey × 2 nights** (Thu 9 Jul AND Mon 13 Jul) — book direct, +1 307-577-1664 (pool, dog park, just off I-25).
- **Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA × 1** (Tue 14 Jul) — book direct, +1 970-484-9880.
- **Park entrance pass** — on Recreation.gov. \$35/vehicle (7 days), OR the \$250 Non-Resident Annual Pass if travelling as UK residents (covers all 4 + every park for a year). **Cowboy store:** Lou Taubert, Casper (Fri 10 Jul, opens 10:00) — no booking.

## Day by day (with departure & arrival times)

### Day 1 — Thu 9 July: Land Denver → Casper

*Driving ~4h30 / 265 mi (after the 1:30 PM pickup & shop)*

**Today's drive**

| Leg                             | Depart       | Arrive       | Drive | Miles |
|---------------------------------|--------------|--------------|-------|-------|
| Commerce City → Casper (I-25 N) | <b>16:00</b> | <b>20:45</b> | 4h30* | 265   |

**11:00** Land at DEN. **11:45** bags, then Road Bear shuttle / Uber to the branch (~20 min) — luggage only, not the RV yet. Grab lunch near the branch.

**13:30 Pickup appointment** (confirmed window 13:30–14:00), 6586 Brighton Blvd. Walkthrough 60–90 min + paperwork; online registration & payment already done (booking CXF847765-1).

**~15:00 Big shop** — Walmart Supercenter, 5990 Dahlia St (5 min from the branch): a week of water, food, snacks, coffee, sealed/zip bags for bear-safe storage, sunscreen, bug spray, torches.

**16:00** North on I-25. **~16:45 Buc-ee's Johnstown** (I-25 exit 252) — giant travel plaza with 100+ fuel pumps (easy RV fill) and a huge store: brisket sandwiches, kolaches, Beaver Nuggets, fudge, jerky. Top up the tank and stock the treats drawer heading into Yellowstone.

**\*~18:15** optional splash-and-dash at Wheatland (~140 mi); summer light to ~21:00.

**~20:45** arrive Casper; cook in or grab dinner.

**Fuel:** Tank starts full. Fill at Buc-ee's (exit 252); optional splash at Wheatland; top up in Casper.

**Overnight:** Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

## Day 2 — Fri 10 July: Casper → Yellowstone — cowboy gear & hot springs

*Driving ~5h50 / 293 mi — the big scenic transit day*

### Today's drive

| Leg                   | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|-----------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Casper → Thermopolis  | 11:45  | 14:00  | 2h15  | 130   |
| Thermopolis → Cody    | 15:30  | 17:10  | 1h40  | 84    |
| Cody → Fishing Bridge | 17:30  | 19:25  | 1h55  | 79    |

**10:00 Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters**, 125 E 2nd St, Casper (opens 10:00) — six floors of Western wear; cowboy hats & boots for the family. ~1h30.

**11:45** Depart Casper; Wind River Canyon en route (2,500-ft walls).

**14:00 Thermopolis** — lunch + a soak at Hot Springs State Park (free State Bath House, ~20-min soak). Wyoming Dinosaur Center next door for the kids.

**15:30** Depart; quick fuel in Cody (~17:10), then the scenic Wapiti Valley and over Sylvan Pass (8,500 ft — steady). ~**19:25** arrive Fishing Bridge (light until ~21:00). Full hookups, showers, laundry. Hard-sided rigs only here — store all food inside.

**Fuel:** FILL IN CODY before the park — last good-value fuel; in-park gas is pricier.

**Overnight:** Fishing Bridge RV Park (night 1 of 2)

## Day 3 — Sat 11 July: Dawn Hayden Valley, then Geysers Loop

*Driving ~3h10 / 128 mi — a dawn wildlife drive, then a geyser loop (no camp move)*

### Today's drive

| Leg                                     | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|-----------------------------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Fishing Bridge → Hayden Valley (dawn)   | 05:15  | 05:40  | 0h25  | 16    |
| Hayden Valley → Fishing Bridge          | 08:00  | 08:25  | 0h25  | 16    |
| Fishing Bridge → West Thumb             | 09:00  | 09:20  | 0h20  | 21    |
| West Thumb → Old Faithful               | 09:30  | 10:05  | 0h35  | 19    |
| Old Faithful → Midway (Grand Prismatic) |        |        | 0h15  | 8     |
| Midway → Fishing Bridge                 | 15:30  | 16:40  | 1h10  | 48    |

**~05:15 Dawn wildlife drive — Hayden Valley** (25 min north): first light is the best wildlife window in the park — big bison herds, elk, and a good chance of grizzly or wolf at distance. Bring binoculars; stay 100 yds from bears/wolves. Back for breakfast ~08:30.

**West Thumb Geyser Basin** — colourful hot springs right on the lakeshore; a quick warm-up boardwalk.

**Old Faithful & Upper Geyser Basin** — check the predicted eruption time, walk the boardwalks (Castle, Grand, Morning Glory Pool) and step inside the historic Old Faithful Inn. Lunch here.

**Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring**, the largest hot spring in the US (Overlook open; check the NPS app for trail closures). A dip on Firehole Canyon Drive on the way is a fun extra.

**Back at Fishing Bridge — same site for a second night.** Full hookups, showers, laundry.

**Fuel:** Fill at the Old Faithful or Grant Village station if low.

**Overnight:** Fishing Bridge RV Park (2nd night)

## Day 4 — Sun 12 July: Fishing Bridge → Canyon → Cody & the Rodeo

*Driving ~3h10 / 133 mi — canyon in the morning, then out to Cody*

### Today's drive

| Leg                                         | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|---------------------------------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Fishing Bridge → Canyon (via Hayden Valley) | 08:00  | 08:45  | 0h45  | 27    |
| Canyon → Fishing Bridge (via Hayden Valley) | 10:45  | 11:30  | 0h45  | 27    |
| Fishing Bridge → East Entrance → Cody       | 11:45  | 13:50  | 1h40  | 79    |

**08:00 Depart Fishing Bridge → Canyon via Hayden Valley** (another good wildlife window) — 45 min.

**Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone** — Artist Point and the Lower Falls; walk a rim viewpoint or two.

**Late morning:** back down through **Hayden Valley** for more wildlife (bison, elk, often grizzly or wolf — stay 100 yds back), past Fishing Bridge and out the East Entrance down the gorgeous Wapiti Valley.

**~14:00 Cody** — the **Buffalo Bill Center of the West** sits on the west side as you arrive (firearms, Plains Indian, art, natural history and Buffalo Bill wings; 2–3h, closes 6 PM) — wear the new hats! Then check in at the KOA on the east edge of town and have a swim.

**19:00** hop the KOA's **free rodeo shuttle** (leaves camp at 7:00 sharp — no driving or parking the rig). **20:00 Cody Nite Rodeo** — ~2 hours of bronc & bull riding, barrel racing and a kids' calf scramble; the shuttle brings you back.

**Fuel:** Fill up in Cody (last good-value fuel) when you arrive.

**Overnight:** Cody / Yellowstone East KOA, +1 307-587-2369 (free rodeo shuttle)

## Day 5 — Mon 13 July: Cody → Casper

*Driving ~3h55 / 214 mi — a relaxed half-day*

### Today's drive

| Leg                  | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|----------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Cody → Thermopolis   | 09:30  | 11:10  | 1h40  | 84    |
| Thermopolis → Casper | 12:30  | 14:45  | 2h15  | 130   |

**Easy morning in Cody** — finish the Buffalo Bill Center, or browse Sheridan Ave for more Western bits.

**11:10 Thermopolis** — a second soak at Hot Springs State Park and lunch, if you fancy it.

**~14:45 Casper** — arrive mid-afternoon with time for the KOA pool and an easy evening before the last stretch.

**Fuel:** Fill in Cody, again in Casper.

**Overnight:** Casper KOA Journey (Bar Nunn), +1 307-577-1664

## Day 6 — Tue 14 July: Casper → Fort Collins (early finish!)

*Driving ~3h30 / 230 mi — on the lake by early afternoon*

### Today's drive

| Leg                            | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|--------------------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Casper → Fort Collins (I-25 S) | 09:00  | 12:45  | 3h30  | 230   |

**09:00** An unhurried start; drive south on I-25 into Colorado.

**~12:45 Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA** — check in early and make the most of it: paddle boats and fishing on the lake, mini-golf, the pool and the jumping pillow.

**Evening:** Old Town Fort Collins (the model for Disney's Main Street USA) and the breweries for a relaxed last dinner.

**Fuel:** Top off near Fort Collins so tomorrow morning is just a quick fill to full.

**Overnight:** Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA, +1 970-484-9880 (on the lake)

## Day 7 — Wed 15 July: Drop the RV → fly home

*Driving ~1h00 / 50 mi*

### Today's drive

| Leg                             | Depart | Arrive | Drive | Miles |
|---------------------------------|--------|--------|-------|-------|
| Fort Collins → Road Bear branch | 08:00  | 09:10  | 1h00  | 50    |

**08:00** Depart Fort Collins south on I-25. **~08:20 Buc-ee's Johnstown** (exit 252) — a fun last stop and cheap fuel; then top the tank to **FULL** near the branch (return full — stations on Brighton Blvd / near I-270).

**~09:10** arrive 6586 Brighton Blvd for your **confirmed 9:30–10:00 AM drop-off**. Your booking includes **Drop & Go** (Platinum Plus) — no tank-dumping or final clean, just hand it back (~30–45 min).

**~10:15** transfer to DEN (~30 min). Be airside by ~12:00 for the **14:05** flight to Orlando.

**Fuel:** Return the tank FULL to avoid the refuel fee.

**Overnight:** Drop-off — Road Bear, Commerce City

## Fuel, supplies & numbers

- **The rig:** Ford E-450 Class C — ~8–10 mpg, ~55-gallon tank (≈ 450–500 mi range, less on grades/AC). Refuel near the half-tank mark.
- **Fuel towns:** **Buc-ee's Johnstown (I-25 exit 252)**, Wheatland/Douglas, Casper, Thermopolis, **Cody (always before the park)**, plus in-park stations at Fishing Bridge, Canyon, Old Faithful and Grant.
- **Rough fuel cost:** ~1,315 mi ÷ 9 mpg ≈ 146 gal × ~\$3.60 ≈ **\$525** for the week.
- **Water & tanks:** full hook-ups both nights at Fishing Bridge — no dry camping on this plan, so no rationing water or dumping mid-trip.

| Item                                           | Rough cost                  |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Park entry (Non-Resident Annual is best value) | \$250, or \$35/veh (7 days) |
| Fishing Bridge RV × 2                          | ~\$94 + tax/night           |
| Casper × 2, Cody × 1, Fort Collins × 1         | ~\$45–75/night              |
| Cody Nite Rodeo × 4 (Sun 12)                   | ~\$25–79/seat               |
| Fuel (week)                                    | ~\$525                      |
| Road Bear rental (booking CXF847765-1)         | settled online              |

## The drive home, mileage & practical notes

- **Why the way home is easy:** instead of one 444-mile Cody→Fort Collins marathon, the rodeo is on **Sunday** night, you overnight in **Casper** on Monday, and Tuesday is a short ~230-mile run — so you reach the Fort Collins lake KOA by early afternoon.
- **Your base:** two nights at Fishing Bridge (full hook-ups, showers, laundry) means no camp move mid-park — you day-trip to the geysers on Saturday and catch the canyon on Sunday morning before heading out. Hard-sided rigs only here (bear country); store all food inside.
- **Mileage:** ~1,315 mi vs the 1,400 included; over that, Road Bear charges ~\$0.45/mile + tax — so you've ~85 miles of headroom for extra wildlife loops.
- **Bears & food:** store food/scented items inside, carry bear spray on walks, keep your distance from wildlife.
- **Signal:** poor-to-none across the park — download offline Google Maps and the NPS app, and keep this itinerary saved or printed.
- **Day-of entry:** Yellowstone needs no timed-entry reservation — just your pass — but check [nps.gov/yell](https://nps.gov/yell) road & closure alerts the morning you go in.

## Web links — tap any name

| Campgrounds                                       | Stops & sights                                          |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">Casper KOA Journey</a>                | <a href="#">Road Bear RV (depot)</a>                    |
| <a href="#">Fishing Bridge RV Park</a>            | <a href="#">Buc-ee's Johnstown</a>                      |
| <a href="#">Cody / Yellowstone East KOA</a>       | <a href="#">Lou Taubert Ranch Outfitters</a>            |
| <a href="#">Fort Collins / Lakeside KOA</a>       | <a href="#">Hot Springs State Park, Thermopolis</a>     |
| <a href="#">Yellowstone NP Lodges (camp res.)</a> | <a href="#">Buffalo Bill Center of the West</a>         |
| <a href="#">Walmart Supercenter (big shop)</a>    | <a href="#">Cody Nite Rodeo (tickets)</a>               |
|                                                   | <a href="#">Yellowstone NP — geysers / Old Faithful</a> |
|                                                   | <a href="#">Yellowstone National Park (official)</a>    |

Cody Nite Rodeo tickets: [codystampederodeo.com](https://codystampederodeo.com) · Yellowstone campground reservations (2026): Yellowstone National Park Lodges, +1 307-344-7311.

Prepared for Mark Williams · distances and times are approximate · confirm campground, rodeo and store availability when booking.